



Qualification Programme Examination Panelist's Report

Module 4 – Business Management (December 2021 Session)

(The main purpose of the following report is to summarise candidates' common weaknesses and make recommendations to help future candidates improve their performance in the examination.)

(I) Section A – Multiple Choice Questions

General Comments

The multiple choice questions tested the candidates' fundamental knowledge of business management in various aspects, including organisational behaviour, general management, finance, marketing, operation management, and decision making, among others. In addition, there were several questions that required candidates to apply a deeper understanding of the concepts and knowledge to different aspects of business management. Candidates had to apply the concepts to simple scenarios presented in the questions.

Generally, candidates' performance was satisfactory, particularly on straightforward questions that tested their basic concepts; however, performance was significantly worse on questions which required candidates to thoroughly study the text or which were related to a specific or difficult topic area, like control or marketing research.

Specific Comments

Candidates showed particular weaknesses in the following areas:

- Control
- Marketing research
- Decision making
- Service management
- Production and operation management
- Organisational behaviour

(II) Section B – Written Questions

General Comments

The questions in this section aimed at testing candidates on their conceptual understanding as well as their ability to apply their knowledge to specific company scenarios. It is very important that the candidates respond to the questions in relation to the specific concepts asked under the different information given in the questions.



In general, candidates did not perform well in most of the questions, especially when they were asked about certain specific concepts and expected to apply the concepts with the information presented in the questions.

Moreover, candidates did not present their answers in an organised way. Many of the candidates put all their points and answers together without separating or paragraphing them point by point. Because some of the points may be quite similar, a lack of organisation makes it more difficult for candidates to present their answers clearly.

Specific Comments

Question 1 – 10 Marks

This question required candidates to describe the diffusion of innovation model and, based on this model, how the company pays attention to consumer segments when producing and promoting products. However, almost no candidate answered this question correctly. Many appeared to have been confused by the segmentation targeting concept, and thus their answers were incorrect or were off topic.

Candidates should pay more attention to important concepts outside of the major topics and areas, such as operation management and production.

Question 2(a) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to identify and explain the control system adopted by the company. Since this question touched on a concept that may be perceived as unimportant, again, almost no candidate was able to tackle the question related to the control system.

As suggested, most of the candidates appear to not have been familiar with control, which they may have viewed as being an unimportant topic. It is advised that candidates should pay more attention to these topics.

Question 2(b) – 8 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the management functions with illustrations from the case information. Some of the candidates were able to provide incomplete answers. They might have been confused with the examples of the functions and, thus, picked an incorrect illustration from the case.

Management functions may have been related to candidates' daily work routines or activities, and, thus, some of them were able to provide the answers or describe the functions. However, they did not have good understanding of the contents of each management function.



Question 3(a) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the service element of the company presented in the scenario. Less than half of the candidates were able to explain the service element adopted. Performance was not satisfactory.

Service concept seems to have been unrelated to most of the candidates' work. Candidates should thus study a wide variety of different topics and concepts in order to be able to tackle all questions on the exam. It is believed that most candidates did not prepare well prior to the examination.

Question 3(b) – 8 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the functions of human resource management involved in the scenario. Many of the candidates were able to explain the human resource management functions involved. This may have been due to the topic of human resource management functions being related to their daily work experiences and routines.

Question 4(a) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to define the concept of stakeholders. This was purely a conceptual question. Most candidates were able to define stakeholder, although most were also unable to provide a complete definition.

It is advised that candidates should try to remember some definitions of the concepts, or at least remember some key points about the concepts.

Question 4(b) – 3 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the factors involved when dealing with conflicting stakeholder interests. Most could not provide an appropriate answer. This question is strongly involved conceptual knowledge, and, thus, candidates were not able to answer it sufficiently.

Question 4(c) – 5 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the stakeholders involved in making financial decisions. This question is also related to stakeholders but in the context of making financial decisions. Given most candidates may work in the financial industry, candidates were able to provide explanations, albeit imperfect ones.



Question 5(a) – 10 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the product life cycle and identify the stage the company in the scenario was in. Candidates were able to explain the four stages of product life cycle but were unable to identify correctly the stage that the company was in. Candidates were unable to differentiate between the stages, and thus, they could not point out when there are competitors entering the market, which should be during the growth stage.

Question 5(b) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the importance of globalisation for the company. Since some factual information was provided in the scenario, most candidates could explain why globalisation was important for the company, which appears to not have been solely based on their knowledge of basic concepts.

Question 5(c) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to explain the factors to be considered when entering a new country for the company. Generally, many students were able to provide the answers as the answers were not solely conceptually based, and students could rely on their common sense or some information given in the scenario to determine the answers.

Question 5(d) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to describe the potential risks that the company should pay attention to when entering international markets. Similar to the above comments, many students were able to describe some of the risks involved. Candidates who did not score high marks did not consider the risks related to the company in addition to the business as a whole.

Question 6(a) – 8 Marks

This question required candidates to differentiate products and services with reference to the company in the scenario. A majority of the candidates were able to differentiate products and services with some aspects but not in full. However, candidates are suggested to be more specific as most of the answers were overly general.

Question 6(b) – 12 Marks

This question required candidates to describe the dimensions of quality for products that the company was producing. However, many of the candidates could not answer this question. This may have been because the question was quite conceptually based and candidates were required to apply the concepts in the text to provide correct answers. Candidates are suggested to study thoroughly.



(III) Conclusion and Recommendation

Overall, the performance of the candidates was not satisfactory. Many of the candidates were able to answer questions related to their daily work activities or to activities they may encounter in their work contexts, allowing them to come up with common sense answers. However, when the questions required the candidates to apply specific concepts, for example, service elements, control systems, stakeholders, the diffusion of innovation model, etc., they had to rely on their preparation of the study text and answer the questions. During this type of situation, candidates did not provide satisfactory answers. Some suggestions are provided below to advise the candidates to prepare for the examination well.

First, candidates are advised to read the study text well. This module encompasses a large spectrum of concepts and theories related to Business Management, and, thus, it is not possible for candidates to simply rely on their common sense or daily work encounters to answer the questions.

Second, most of the questions ask candidates to relate the answers to the concepts and apply the answers to the scenarios. This means it is not sufficient for candidates to only provide applications without proper reference to the concepts. Thus, related to the first suggestion, a good preparation of the study text is important.

Third, in presenting their answers and ideas, it is advised that candidates should organise the points well. It would be wise to only write one point per paragraph. Or the candidates can use a topic sentence to highlight the key points of the answers.